

THE LAST OF INDIA'S TEST PURISTS

For over a decade, Cheteshwar Pujara **stood tall** at No. 3 for India. He now departs as he batted — understated, steadfast, and oddly timeless.

Ayan Acharya

ayan.acharya@thehindu.co.in

When Cheteshwar Pujara announced his retirement from all forms of the game, there was no great fanfare, no curated montage, no carefully scripted farewell. That was never his way.

He departed as he batted — understated, steadfast, and oddly timeless. Yet, Indian cricket, and Test cricket itself, will feel the hollow left behind.

For over a decade, Pujara stood at No. 3 for India, the position once occupied by Rahul Dravid, and produced 7,195 runs in 103 Tests at an average of 43.60. That is the statistical summary, but it tells only part of the story.

What endures is the manner in which those runs were made: the patience of a mason laying brick upon brick, the stubborn refusal to be hurried, the willingness to suffer on behalf of the team.

His journey began in December 2005 with a debut for Saurashtra in the Ranji Trophy. It ended this year in the same whites, a circle closing neatly, loyally. His Test debut arrived in Bengaluru in 2010 against Australia, the side that would define his legend. He was central to India's two historic series victories in Australia. In 2018–19, he scored three centuries and faced 1,258



Safeguard: Pujara produced 7,195 runs in 103 Tests at an average of 43.60. VIJAY SONEJI